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*Expansion and Enclosure: Ritual Landscapes and the Politics of Space in Central Malawi**

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The article explores historical change in the relationship between two important ritual institutions among the Chewa in Central Malawi. Focusing on the territorial rain shrine at Bunda and the village-based mask societies of nyau, both institutions are seen to form a ritual landscape that informs people's practices and perceptions. While, at the level of ideology, the significance of this arrangement still holds, in actual practice many of the interlocking rules and norms have been given up. The article illustrates this situation by referring to the different developments in the two institutions. While the rain shrine has diminished in importance the mask societies have thrived. Using Appadurai's theory of locality as a heuristic tool, it is argued that the decline of the former is linked to the flourishing of the latter. Rather than becoming enshrined and encapsulated, as has happened with the rain shrine, nyau have managed to remain in command of the ritual media and techniques to produce a meaningful context for social action and identity. In view of the ongoing political and economic crisis of the Malawian nation-state, on the one hand, and the (relative) success of nyau, on the other, this development has led to a reshaping and reordering of the relationship between the rural and the urban in contemporary Malawi.

Ritual, Locality and Context

The recent debate on landscape has sharpened our insights into the understanding of landscape not only as a social and aesthetic category but also as a 'cultural process'.¹ Rituals play a prominent role in this process for they not only produce landscapes by imbuing space with moral values, ideas and perceptions, but are also capable of changing them. The title of this essay – expansion and enclosure – refers to such a change. As such it denotes a distinctive change in the ritual landscape in central Malawi, an area where I have been conducting my fieldwork.² The specific ethnography that is the focus of this

* This essay has profited from discussions with numerous friends and colleagues. In particular, I would like to thank Ute Luig for sensible insights and critique. Her work on Tonga spirit possession stimulated this essay. Further valuable comments came from Harri Englund, Kings Phiri, Claude Boucher, Martin Ott, Douglas Curran, Jan Kees van Donge and Megan Vaughan. Special thanks go to Paul Chipwaira, Alex Chigoneka and Luciano Chembe who helped me to understand.

1 For understanding landscapes as a 'cultural process' see E. Hirsch and M. O'Hanlon (eds), *The Anthropology of Landscapes* (Oxford, Clarendon Press, 1996). For other works on this topic see C. Tilley, *A Phenomenology of Landscape: Places, Paths and Monuments* (London, Berg, 1994); U. Luig and A. von Oppen (eds), 'The Making of African Landscapes', *Paideuma*, 43, special issue (1997); T. Ranger, *Voices from the Rocks. Nature, Culture and History in the Matopo Hills of Zimbabwe* (Harare, Baobab, 1999).

2 The fieldwork on which this article is based was carried out in the district of Lilongwe South (Malawi) during numerous phases, mainly between 1994 and 1997, with an additional short period in 2000. Funding has come from the Free University Berlin/Faculty of Philosophy and Social Sciences II, the Humanities Collaborative Research Centre at the University of Bayreuth, Germany, and the German Research Council [DFG]. The assistance of these institutions is gratefully acknowledged.

paper is the shift in the relationship between the territorial *chisumphi* rain shrine at Bunda and the village-based mask societies of *nyau* in the district of Lilongwe South. Representing the most important ritual features of Chewa society, both institutions are closely interwoven with one another, creating a complex spatial arrangement of political, religious and economic relationships and activities. As we will see, contrary to many assumptions that predicted a decline of *nyau* under the impact of outside (ie Western) forces and influences,³ *nyau* masked performances have maintained their popularity among the people. Moreover, the spatial reach of *nyau* has increased over the last 30 to 40 years, with *nyau* associations now forming closely organised ritual networks that are spread over wide areas of Central Malawi. In contrast, the territorial rain shrines that once symbolised the spatial influence of their chiefly owners have been losing their importance or have been abandoned.

Although the shift seems drastic, it is far from new. The decline of the *chisumphi* rain cult has been commented on for as long as it has also been noted that *nyau* was on the increase⁴ (despite the predictions of decline noted above). In fact, as we will see below, the notion of decay and degeneration characterise much of the anthropological and historical literature that has been written since the 1950s and 1960s. Thus, the changing nature of the ritual landscape in Central Malawi has been known for some time, although a detailed analysis of the complexity of this change is still missing. Anthropological and historical research has usually focused on either the rain cults or on *nyau*.⁵ Studies investigating the linkages and interdependence between these two ritual institutions did so only in terms of illuminating the cosmological principles, thereby operating on a synchronic level.⁶ A diachronic analysis aimed at understanding the historical changes in a common framework combining cosmological with social and political issues has been missing.⁷

In this paper I set out to provide such a framework by combining the perspective on

3 W. H. J. Rangeley, 'Nyau in Kotakota District, Part I', *Nyasaland Journal*, 1, 2 (1949), pp. 35–49; W. H. J. Rangeley, 'Nyau in Kotakota District, Part II', *Nyasaland Journal*, 3, 2 (1950), pp. 19–33; G. Kubik, *Nyau Maskenbuende im suedlichen Afrika* (Wien, Verlag der Oesterreichischen Akademie der Wissenschaften, 1987).

4 See, for example, V. E. Munby, 'Heathenism in the Hill Districts', *Central Africa*, 41 (1923), pp. 77–78; R. Stuart, 'Anglican Missionaries and a Chewa Dini: Conversion and Rejection in Central Malawi', *Journal of Religion in Africa*, 10, 1 (1980), p. 63; I. Linden, *Catholics, Peasants and Chewa Resistance in Nyasaland. 1899–1939* (London, Heinemann, 1976).

5 The literature is complex. For the rain shrine see, for example, W. H. J. Rangeley, 'Two Nyasaland Rainshrines: Makewana, the Mother of all People', *Nyasaland Journal*, 5, 2 (1950), pp. 31–50; W. H. J. Rangeley, 'Mbona the Rainmaker', *Nyasaland Journal*, 6, 1 (1951), pp. 8–27; J. P. Bruwer, 'Remnants of a Raincult among the Achewa', *African Studies*, 7 (1952), pp. 197–182; J. M. Schoffeleers, 'The religious significance of bushfires in Malawi', *Cahiers des Religions Africaines*, 5, 10 (1971), pp. 271–281; J. M. Schoffeleers, 'The Chisumphi and Mbona Cults in Malawi', in J. M. Schoffeleers (ed), *Guardians of the Land* (Gwelo, Mambo Press, 1979), pp. 147–187; J. M. Schoffeleers, *River of Blood. The Genesis of Martyr Cult in Southern Malawi* (Madison, University of Wisconsin Press, 1992); for *nyau* see W. H. J. Rangeley, 'Nyau in Kotakota District'; Kubik, *Nyau Maskenbuende*; J. M. Schoffeleers, 'The Nyau Societies: Our Present Understanding', *Society of Malawi Journal*, 29, 7 (1976), pp. 59–69; D. Kaspin, 'Chewa Visions and Revisions of Power: Transformations of the Nyau Dance in Central Malawi', in J. Comaroff and J. Comaroff (eds), *Modernity and its Malcontents* (Chicago, Chicago University Press, 1993), pp. 34–57; K. Yoshida, 'Masks and Secrecy among the Chewa' in *African Arts*, 26, 2, pp. 34–45; L. Birch de Aguiar, *Inscribing the Mask. Interpretation of Nyau Masks and Ritual Performance among the Chewa* (Fribourg, Fribourg University Press, 1996); P. Probst, 'Dancing AIDS. Moral Discourses and Ritual Authority', *Sozialanthropologische Arbeitspapiere* (Freie Universitaet Berlin 1995); P. Probst, 'Danser le Sida. Spectacles du nyau et culture populaire Chewa dans le centre du Malawi', *Autrepart*, NS, 1, 1, pp. 91–112; P. Probst, *Kalumbas Fest: zum Wandel Ritweller Landschaften in Zentral Malawi* (Unveroeffentlichte Habilitationsschrift, Universitaet Bayreuth, 2001).

6 J. M. Schoffeleers, 'Symbolic and Social Aspects of Spirit Worship among the Mang'anja' (PhD Dissertation, University of Oxford, 1968); J. W. M. van Breugel, 'Traditional Chewa Religious Beliefs and Practices' (PhD Dissertation, University of London, 1976); D. Kaspin, 'Elephants and Ancestors, The Legacy of Kingship in Rural Malawi' (PhD Dissertation, University of Chicago, 1991); K. Yoshida, 'Masks and Transformation among the Chewa of Eastern Zambia', *Senri Ethnological Studies*, 31 (1992), pp. 203–274.

7 An outstanding exception, which has informed the present analysis, is Matthew Schoffeleers' detailed paper on 'Chisumphi and Mbona Cults'.

ritual landscape with Arjun Appadurai's thoughts on the dialectical nature of locality.⁸ In his view, localities need to be seen as contexts insofar as they provide frames for the production of social life worlds. Seen in this way, Appadurai argues, localities are not only 'context generative', they are also 'context driven'. That is, just as localities produce design, shape and 'generate' the social actions of those who inhabit them, they also derive their specific qualities by standing in relation to other spatially organised structures or units that 'drive' the localities as part of that particular context. Given this dialectical constellation, key features of the relational character of locality are power and political economy. This is because the capability of localities to produce local subjects and a meaningful context is always affected by other larger scale formations/localities, such as kingdoms, nation-states, colonial empires, trading companies or mission networks. The latter not only shape the localities within their social reach, but quite often also drastically limit the context-producing activities of the local subjects. Thus, the conditions under which the construction of locality takes place, and the effects of that construction, are hardly ever matters of social preference but of power and the specific means to resist that power.

Following Appadurai's ideas as a theoretical guide for the interpretation of the ethnographic case material, this paper is organised into four parts. First, *nyau* and *chisumphi* are contextualised in the wider regional framework of ritual institutions in southern central Africa and an outline is given of the specific situation in Lilongwe South. The second part describes how locality is produced by the Bunda rain shrine and the mask society of *nyau*. Part three analyses the historical transformations between the two institutions. In the fourth and final part the relative success of *nyau* in comparison to the Bunda rain shrine is explained and its effects and consequences in terms of the changing political and economic scenery within the area in question are examined.

Chisumphi and Nyau: Variations on a Ritual Theme in South Central Africa?

A particularly useful example of the value of Appadurai's argument has recently been provided by Ute Luig.⁹ Using Appadurai's theory of context for her analysis of the changing relationship between the *basangu* and the *masabe* spirit possession cults among the Tonga in Southern Zambia, Luig was able to show that the increase and relative success of the *masabe* vis-à-vis the *basangu* cults rests on the way the former has been able to cope with outside influences. As she argues, 'While both are engaged in locality production, they differ in the way they cope with the situation when the conditions of the production of locality have changed'.¹⁰

As will become clear in this paper, the dynamics of the relationship between *chisumphi* and *nyau* are basically very similar. Both institutions belong to a wider cult complex that comprises not only the Chewa and Tonga in Malawi and Zambia but also similar institutions in Zimbabwe, Mozambique, Tanzania and beyond.¹¹ Thus, whereas the territorial cults of the Shona *mhondoro* and Tonga *basangu* resemble the *chisumphi* cult among

8 A. Appadurai, 'The Production of Locality' in R. Fardon (ed), *Counterwork: Managing the Diversity of Knowledge* (London, Routledge, 1995), pp. 204–225; A. Appadurai, *Modernity at Large. The Cultural Dimension of Globalisation* (Minneapolis, Minneapolis University Press, 1996).

9 U. Luig, 'Constructing Local Worlds. Spirit Possession in the Gwembe Valley', in H. Behrend and U. Luig (eds), *Spirit Possession, Modernity and Power in Africa* (Oxford, James Currey, 1999), pp. 124–141.

10 Luig, *Local Worlds*, p. 137.

11 B. Heintze, *Besessenheitsphänomene im mittleren Bantu-Gebiet* (Wiesbaden, Steiner, 1970), Schoffeleers (ed), *Guardians of the Land*; W. Peterman, *Regenkulte und Regenmacher bei Bantu-sprachigen Ethnien Ost- und Südafrikas* (Berlin, Edition Express, 1985); R. van Dijk et al (eds), *The Quest for Fruition through Ngoma* (Oxford, James Currey, 2000).

the Chewa, the *mashave* and *masabe* correspond with *nyau*. Although the latter is a masked society and not a cult of affliction, we find the marked emphasis on alterity that prevails in *masave* and *masabe* in *nyau* as well. For example, the masks of *nyau* are generally referred to as *zirombo*, 'wild animals', who come from the bush into the village in order to accompany the difficult passages from youth to maturity and from life over death to the realm of the ancestors. The imagery used in this context ranges from crocodiles, elephants and lions, to bicycles, trains, missionaries and politicians etc. Thus, the imagery of *nyau* resembles the imagery we find in the *mashave* and *masabe* possession cults.¹² Indeed, some of the names and characteristic ritual attributes can be found in both cult complexes.¹³ In addition, the constant invention of new figures drawn from the everyday experience of the local population is common to both groups.

As tempting as these similarities might seem, the differences should not be ignored. The role of the *basangu* among the Tonga differs from that of the *mhondoro* among the Shona. The latter seem to have maintained their influence much more than their Tonga counterparts.¹⁴ Although recent studies on the Shona *masabe* are lacking, like the Tonga *mashave* they seem to have more in common with the *vimbuza* cult among the Tumbuka than with the mask societies of *nyau* among the Chewa.¹⁵ Furthermore the keeper of the rain shrine at Bunda, the most important rain shrine among the Chewa, is not a spirit medium. His role involves neither political nor spirit possession.¹⁶ The next section of the paper takes a close look at the area in question.

Kalumba and Chilowa: Two Biographies

Chief Kalumba is the head of a small village some thirty km south of Lilongwe and an owner of *nyau*. Chief Chilowa is the keeper of the *chisumpi* rain shrine in Bunda, about 10 km north of Kalumba. Their two distinctly different biographies exemplify not only the specific interlocking of two single individuals with colonial and post-colonial transformations in this particular area of Malawi but also, and much more vividly than any abstract description could, the result of the recent shift within the relationship of *chisumphi* and *nyau*.

Chief Kalumba, a man in his sixties, was installed in the early 1990s. He is the chief of a village that lies in the vicinity of Mitundu, the most important trading centre in the district. However, Kalumba himself lives in Lilongwe together with his wife, his son and his two daughters. Every month, or when the situation requires it, he goes to his village to hear cases and decide pressing issues. During his absence his sister's son takes charge of village affairs.

Kalumba did not want to become a chief. His life had led him in quite a different direction. Born in 1940, he left his village when he was fourteen. His parents sent him to Dedza where he attended primary school. In the late 1950s he moved to Likuni Boys Secondary School in Lilongwe, which is also where he met his present wife. After

12 See U. Luig, *Local Worlds*; E. Colson, 'Spirit Possession among the Tonga in Zambia', in J. Beattie and J. Middleton (eds), *Spirit Mediumship and Society in Africa* (London, Routledge and Kegan Paul, 1969), pp. 69–103; M. Gelfand, *Shona Ritual* (Capetown, Juta Publications, 1959); D. Lan, *Guns and Rain. Guerrillas and Spirit Mediums in Zimbabwe* (Oxford, James Currey, 1985).

13 The most prominent example constitutes the figure of *kapoli*, see G. Kubik, *Makisi, Nyau, Mapiko. Maskentraditionen im bantu-sprachigen Afrika* (Wuppertal, Hammer, 1993), p. 159; Lan, *Guns*, p. 160; Gelfand, *Shona Ritual*.

14 See Ranger, *Voices*.

15 See S. M. Friedson, *Dancing Prophets. Musical Experience in Tumbuka Healing* (Chicago, Chicago University Press 1996), L. Vail and L. White, *Power and the Praise Poem* (Charlottesville, University of Virginia Press, 1991).

16 The material presented by Schoffeleers (*Chisumphi and Mbona*) suggests, however, that in pre-colonial times spirit mediumship might well have been a feature at Bunda as well.

graduation he studied at the Colby College of Agriculture, a colonial institution that was later replaced by the Bunda College of Agriculture. After independence, Kalumba worked as a field assistant for the government. In the early 1970s, a scholarship took him to the United States where he stayed for two years. In subsequent years he had two other scholarships to the US. Step by step he climbed the ladder in government service. At home, he became a respected elder in the Catholic church. However, change came with the decline of the Banda regime. In 1991, shortly after his return from his last trip to the US, Kalumba was made the new chief of his village. To go back to the village was felt to be impossible, for Kalumba was still active in the ministry. However, the political changes also brought an end to Kalumba's professional career. In 1993, the year that the Malawian people decided to abolish Kamuzu Banda's one party system in a public referendum, he was sent into early retirement. Then the demands from his village became stronger. However, there were delicate issues involved concerning Kalumba's attitude towards *nyau*. As a respected elder in the Catholic church, Kalumba at first rejected *nyau*. Nevertheless, a year later, and very much against the will of his wife, he decided to do his *mkangali*, a female puberty rite which also serves as the ritual ratification of the status of the chief presiding over *nyau*. Since then, Kalumba has become an active member in the expanding world of *nyau*. He presides over the funeral and initiation ceremonies during which *nyau* dancers perform. He also takes an active interest in enhancing the prestige of his own *nyau* society by providing money and material for new costumes and masks, thereby improving the entertainment element of his village's mask dancers when they compete with dancers from other villages for the favour of the audience.

In Kalumba's view his new life does not conflict with his earlier one. Rather, he argues, the decision to take over the responsibility for *nyau* by doing *mkangali* was something that had 'to do with home'. In other words it was a decision acknowledging a specific feeling of spatial belonging and ethnic identity that was localised, as well as symbolised, by *nyau*.¹⁷

Chief Chilowa is the present keeper of the *chisumphu* rain shrine at Bunda and a relative of Chief Kalumba – Chilowa's father was the brother of the second chief of Kalumba. Born roughly around the same year as Kalumba, Chilowa's life took a very different course. Western education or a career beyond the rural sphere was never an option. While Kalumba was away from home and at school, Chilowa stayed in his village and followed his uncle during his trips to the shrine and his various ritual duties.

From childhood he was trained to take over his uncle's office as keeper of the shrine. In the early 1970s, when Bunda College of Agriculture was being built and Kalumba got the scholarship that took him to the US, Chilowa was installed as the new keeper of the Bunda rain shrine – the last remnant of what had once been an important religious and political institution spread throughout the central region of Malawi. The shrine still has a high reputation among the people: the fact that Bunda College of Agriculture was built right next to the shrine was partly so that the shrine could lend the new post-colonial project a certain traditional aura. Yet Chilowa knows that, even for an important institution such as Bunda, it has now become difficult to conduct the rituals properly. He is doing his best, but he admits that his office is losing its importance. He complains that people no longer stick to the rules laid down by the ancestors. Today only the annual burning of the Bunda mountain takes place. The *mfunde*, the rain calling ritual that used to be carried out in February in times of drought or excessive rain, has been given up. The last one Chilowa

17 In this way Kalumba is not alone. *Nyau* societies flourish in the Chewa diasporas of neighbouring Zambia and Zimbabwe just as Chewa pose in *nyau* costumes on the internet to confess that: 'you can take me out of Malawi but you can't take the Malawian out of me', see www.fukula.tripod.com/nyau.htm

remembers took place in the 1950s when he was still a child. What is more important, however, is the penetration of *nyau* into the domain of the rain cult.

In principle, both institutions, the rain cult and *nyau*, stand in a relationship of mutual exclusion to each other. Village chiefs who act as ritual officials in the rain cult are not allowed to hold *nyau* and village chiefs who possess *nyau* are not allowed to take part in the sacrifices brought to the ancestors and the God Above at the rain shrine. People explain this rule as being analogous to the attitude of the Christian Church towards paganism. It is common to hear Chewa people equate the rain shrine with the Christian Church. Just as the Catholic church forbids its members to become members of the pagan institution of *nyau*, with sinners being punished with ex-communication, *chauta* (see below) forbids the presence of *nyau* within the premises of the shrine and in the villages of the shrine officials. Today, however, this prohibition is no longer honoured, even if it remains the ideal. Chilowa accepted the introduction of *nyau* into his village in the 1970s, shortly after his installation, a decision officially strictly forbidden by tradition. But Chilowa was not the only one. Among the eight chiefs who act as cult officials of the Bunda shrine today, only the (ritual) owner of the shrine, T. A. Chadza, still respects the avoidance rule. The others hold *nyau* in their villages.¹⁸ All of them obtained *nyau* from the late 1970s onwards, a time of some significance, as will be explained further below.

The characters of Kalumba and Chilowa depict the themes of this essay expressed in its title, *expansion and enclosure*. In the case of Chilowa, this means that the world he and the shrine once stood for has become increasingly encapsulated. The social reach of the rituals conducted at the shrine has shrunk to a very local and localised affair. The outer world the rituals appeal to has turned into an inner world. Today, only Chilowa and his fellow chiefs obey the rules the cult demands but even they have given in to the dominance of *nyau* by introducing the masks into their own domain. In contrast to this, Kalumba embodies the opposite development. In his case, the local word of *nyau* has not only become part of his biographically grown outer world but has triumphed over it by integrating the latter into its own rules and regulations. To understand these divergences we have to explore how the two cults create localities as meaningful contexts of social action and identities.

Cracks and Ruptures: Producing Locality at Bunda

As mentioned above, Chilowa differs from his Shona and Tonga counterparts in the sense that he is not considered to be a spirit medium. Yet Bunda also acts as a regional or territorial cult.¹⁹ That is to say, the meaning of the institution lies in its capacity to generate processes of territorialisation, understood here as appropriations of space as a social field that bind the subjects living and acting in it to a certain moral order of values, perceptions, practices and meanings, thereby separating this field from other fields with different moral orders.²⁰ Based upon the experience of seasonal periodicity, a set of complex analogies

18 The picture presented above is not restricted to the rain shrine at Bunda. A similar picture characterises the situation at the other territorial rain shrines in the central region of Malawi. At Tsangoma, for example, about 15 km south-west of Bunda, number two in the ritual hierarchy of the Chewa rain shrines, the shrine still exists but the respective rituals are no longer carried out. The various shrine officials quarrel over status issues and the fact that some chiefs have *nyau* while others do not. Shrine activities have also stopped at Chilenje in the Nkhoma mountains and near Salima on the lake. The same applies to the Chewa rain shrines in neighbouring Zambia where the rituals stopped some time ago: see J. P. Bruwer, *Remnants*.

19 R. Werbner, 'Introduction', in R. Werbner (ed), *Regional Cults* (New York, Academic Press, 1977), pp. ix—xxxvii; J. M. Schoffeleers, 'Introduction', in Schoffeleers (ed), *Guardians of the Land*.

20 The term 'moral' is understood here in the performative characterisation of Niklas Luhmann as 'a certain way of communication which entails and carries along hints on respect and disrespect'. See N. Luhmann, *Paradigm Lost: Über die ethische Funktion von Moral* (Frankfurt, Suhrkamp, 1996).

between land and office, and mutual processes of externalisation and internalisation of moral knowledge woven around the shrine and its ritual officials, Bunda can be seen as a place where these processes of territorialisation are generated.

The ritual 'logic' by which this is done has been demonstrated by Schoffeleers and more recently by Kaspin.²¹ Bunda rain rituals are organised in relation to agricultural production and the seasonal change from the rainy season (December to May) to the dry season (June to November). In this way, the seasonal cycle of agricultural production, mainly the cultivation of maize, corresponds with the calendrical cycle of ceremonies. Thus, the burning of Bunda mountain in August ritually marks the beginning of the hot season and, at the same time, also the beginning of the ritual season during which *nyau* performs. This is the time after the harvest when enough food is available to feed guests at the initiation rituals and burial commemorative festivals held during the dry season. It is also the time when people start clearing the fields by setting brush fires. Week after week black smoke rises from the fields, darkening the sky. As if transforming the smoke into rain, at the beginning of November the first rain clouds arrive. These rains mark the end of the ritual season and signify the beginning of planting. Planting lasts until early December when the great rains come, which close the agricultural cycle and start a new one.

As can be seen, the calendrical rites ensure seasonal rotations within a cyclical cosmological system in which pathways of return are established from the recipients of the earth's productivity back to its source. The source is *chisumphi*, the latter being another name for *chauta*, meaning 'the great rainbow'. The image of the rainbow depicts the magnitude of *chisumphi* who stretches over the earth and releases the rain from the sky that generates processes of growth on the land. From the land, the rising smoke from the burning of Bunda mountain and the bush fires that follow, are the path of return back to the sky. Thus, the rain rituals appear as a kind of ritual refraction of the cosmological principle, which has its roots in the Chewa myth of creation.²²

A basic theme in the various versions of this myth is that life began with a primal rain during which men and animals fell from heaven. In the beginning all lived together in peace and harmony. The subsequent invention of fire by men, however, ended this. Men and animals fled in different directions and dispersed. The place where this is believed to have happened is Kapiri Ntiwa, a hill in the Dzalanyama range on the border with Mozambique. It was only a long time afterwards, when the ancestors of the Chewa people migrated into their present habitat that they discovered Kapiri Ntiwa as the place where all life began. In praise of the primal events they erected a rain shrine at Msinja, the first Chewa rain shrine. In the course of the political differentiation of Chewa society other shrines followed, including Bunda. The history of its owner, chief Chadza, is said to go back to the time of Makewana, the first rain medium at Msinja, and the great kingdoms of Undi and Kalonga.

It is beyond the scope of this essay to describe the numerous allusions to the creation myth, and its historical and political implications, entailed in the various ritual duties of Chief Chadza and his fellow chiefs. It suffices to refer to Kaspin's subtle study wherein she argues for the existence of a cultural memory that unites the people living in the area and binds them together through a shared set of local knowledge based upon practices of inscription and embodiment.²³

As elegant and convincing as Kaspin's analysis seems, one needs to pluralise the concept of cultural memory and remembrance. The political history of Chewa society, with

21 See Schoffeleers, *Bushfires*; D. Kaspin, 'A Chewa Cosmology of the Body', *American Ethnologist*, 23, 3 (1996), pp. 561–578.

22 On the various parts of this 'myth' put together by Schoffeleers, see Schoffeleers, *Spirit Worship*.

23 See Kaspin, *Chewa Cosmology*.

its numerous fissions and segmentations into small autonomous units, has led to a great variety of local histories whose remembrance varies according to the different interests and intentions of their members. In these local histories, the great narrative of Msinja and Makewana tends to be relegated to a pale and distant past. To a large extent the legends and oral traditions about Msinja recorded by Rangeley in the 1940s are lost.²⁴ Even Chilowa, whose office is modelled after Makewana, has only a vague knowledge of that figure. Similarly, the ritual climate of the area has changed. The 'cool' atmosphere required for the rain shrine sacrifices cannot be created any longer. Just as people no longer follow the rule of sexual abstinence during rain shrine rituals, the 'hot' *nyau* have encroached into the 'cool' domain of the rain shrine. In other words, the creation of a moral landscape turns out to be fragmented. The conceptual and praxeological pattern, which was once institutionally grounded in the expanded network of Msinja and its various offshoots, has become reduced to, and condensed in, one shrine only, Bunda. Instead of the principle of territoriality, we find that of locality. In this way, moral knowledge and moral memory still exist, but their normative value is no longer attached to the wider region but to the village.

'Something to do with Home': Producing Locality in *Nyau*

As will be remembered, chief Kalumba explained his decision to do *mkangali* by stating that it had 'something to do with home'. The phrase is an apt illustration of Appadurai's characterisation of locality as a 'structure of feeling'.²⁵ Thus, what is at stake are the specific emotional and aesthetic qualities of locality. In the Chewa context these qualities are perhaps best expressed in the words *mwambo* and *miambo*. When people speak of *mwambo*, they refer to something that can be best translated as 'tradition' or 'customs'. In its plural form, the word *miambo* refers to the numerous codes learnt during male and female initiation. Both words are related to the verb *kumva*, meaning to hear, to understand or to feel. In other words, within the initiation the novices actually hear, understand and 'feel' the *miambo*, the secret codes. They learn to master certain bodily movements, they have to memorise riddles, the use of secret language and much more. These *miambo* form the core of what is considered to be a proper Chewa person and the way they are acquired is a highly aesthetic, highly sensual undertaking involving the whole body and appealing directly to basic emotions like lust and fear, hope and despair. It was for these reasons that Kalumba's wife, who rejected his move to perform *mkangali* on Christian grounds, cried while dancing with her husband over the village dance ground. She not only feared the sanctions of the Catholic church for her active participation in a pagan ritual but also sensed that initiation into *nyau* meant to cross a border and to become incorporated into a domain whose ground rules are decidedly distinct from those of her former life as a member of the Catholic church and teacher in downtown Lilongwe.

The place where all this took place was the village or, to be precise, the moral idea of the village as it is constructed by *nyau* performances. Indeed, the very learning of the *miambo* is embedded in the mortuary and initiation ceremonies that constitute the two main occasions for the appearance of *nyau*, whose performances can be seen as processes of ritual destruction and recreation of the spatial boundaries of the village as a moral and social universe.

Chewa mortuary rituals are subdivided into two phases, a burial rite and a commemorative rite. The former takes place immediately after someone's death and is essentially a

24 Rangeley, *Two Nyasaland Rainshrines*.

25 Appadurai, *Production*, p. 208. Actually, the phrase stems from Raymond Williams who used it in his treatment of the concept of home! See R. Williams, *The Long Revolution* (London, Faber 1968).

rite of appropriation as the ancestor spirits (sing. *mzimu*) come to claim their own. *Nyau* comes to attend the burial, but only the day masks that represent the spirits of the dead. The night masks, the wild animals from the bush, remain hidden. They make their appearance only after the following harvest when enough food and beer is available to feed the participants. The time between is a period of transition, not only for the surviving kin but also for the ghost (*chiwanda*) of the deceased who is considered to roam the village waiting to be transformed into a *mzimu* proper. For this, however, the performance of the night masks is required. Their appearance coincides with the final stages of beer brewing, a task done by the women. Before the beer is ready, the *zirombo*, the 'wild beasts', only appear at the outskirts of the village, producing dangerous sounds. When the beer is ready they come together with the day masks to dance in the village. By transgressing the boundaries between inside and outside the village they enter the realm of the living where they capture the spirit of the deceased and return with him to the graveyard, where both the *nyau* and the ancestors rest.²⁶

What is remarkable in *nyau* performances is how space is socially organised within the ritual. As described above, the three main spatial categories – inside, outside and in-between – correspond to the three different categories of participants: women, nocturnal masks and diurnal masks. Chewa descent and residence rules make women or, to be more precise, the sorority group, *mbumba*, the stable and fixed inner pole of village society. Outside the village is the bush, the realm of the wild animals represented by the nocturnal masks. The job of hunting these beasts is done by men, the last category, who dance with the diurnal masks and whose restless moving between bush and village during the ritual not only mirrors their predatory activities but also their role within the framework of Chewa social organisation.²⁷ Due to the total phenomenon of *nyau*, this threefold relationship can be interpreted in many ways. But whether one primarily sees in them the very embodiment of Chewa religion or impressive metaphors of sexuality and fertility, *nyau* performances are also always elaborate articulations of how Chewa define and demarcate the boundaries of their social and moral universe.²⁸

In this context, two features – let us call them transition and catharsis – are clearly recognisable in relation both to the social and the spatial elements involved. From the beginning until the middle of the ritual only the diurnal figures enter the village, thereby constantly violating the spheres of belonging. This violation reaches its climax at the end of the ritual when the nocturnal figures enter the village. Their appearance denotes not only the total breakdown of the spheres but also the process of establishing them anew. Thus, socially, as well as spatially, the *nyau* ritual constantly demolishes and recreates the very boundaries upon which the identity and distinctiveness of Chewa society rest, not only in relation to the other members of society 'within', but also *vis-à-vis* other social groups 'outside'.²⁹

The fact that these boundaries have been and still are constantly contested can be seen

26 Puberty rituals for boys and for girls follow a similar scenario; see D. Kaspin, 'A Lion at the Waterhole. The Secrets of Life and Death at Chewa Initiation Rites', in H. Moore (ed), *Those who Play with Fire. Gender, Fertility and Transformation in East and Southern Africa* (London, Athlone Press, 1999), pp. 83–99.

27 See B. Morris, 'Woodland and the Village: Reflections on the "Animal Estate" in Rural Malawi', *Journal of the Royal Anthropological Institute*, NS, 1, pp. 301–315; Brian Morris, *The Power of Animals* (London, Berg, 1998).

28 See Yoshida's illuminating analysis in *Transformations*, p. 238.

29 It would be misleading to see *nyau* as a kind of 'cultural laboratory' creating a pure inner moral space. Rather, *nyau* performances constitute a sort of localised forum of diverse intentions that are held together by common assumptions, a forum then very much in the sense of Bakhtin's 'zone' that is 'both a territory and a sphere of influence'. See M. Bakhtin, *The Dialogic Imagination* (Austin, University of Texas Press, 1992). In this way, *nyau* performances always entail multiple, and at times conflicting, perceptions and readings of events; see Probst, 'Dancing AIDS. Moral Discourses and Ritual Authority', and 'Danser le Sida'.

in the numerous new masks within the *nyau* repertoire. Christian-colonial inspired inventions such as *simoni* or *maliya* or more recent ones like *edzi* (for AIDS) or *bakili* (for Bakili Muluzi, Malawi's new president who succeeded Kamuzu Banda in 1994) illustrate how *nyau* digests experiences alien to the local village sphere. This is illustrative of the issue of changing contexts and the above-mentioned question of the uneven capabilities of *nyau* and the *chisumphi* rain shrine to construct localities as context *and* to handle the contexts of localities.

From Decentralisation to Instrumentalisation: Changing Contexts I

As noted above, the rain shrine and the mask society are closely related to each other. In fact, Schoffeleers has argued that just as the *chisumphi* rain cult reflects the logic of the creation myth, *nyau* performances can be seen as enacting the mythical time of unity, with the anthropomorphic and zoomorphic masks as embodiments of both the ancestors and the animals.³⁰ Be this as it may, perhaps the best indicator of the relationship between the two institutions is a riddle each novice has to memorise when initiated into *nyau*. It lists the various stages of a zoomorphic *nyau* figure from the very beginning of its construction, from maize husks gathered after the maize has been harvested, until the end when the figure is burned at the graveyard. The life cycle of the figure the riddle describes is embedded in the seasonal cycle and the calendrical rituals of the rain cult, which means that the world constructed by *nyau* is part of the world constructed by the *chisumphi* rain cult and at the same time an inversion of it.

Oral tradition hints at an explanation of this convergence by stating that the rain shrine and *nyau* originally belonged to one single ritual complex. However, due to the shedding of blood, the two became separated.³¹ This incident correlates with another tradition, which explains the origin of the names of the first two Chewa clans and their relationship to one another:

One day two groups went about in search of arrowroots and some edible roots. They did not return home but slept in the bush. One group slept on a hilltop and the other at the foot of the hill. When morning came, those who slept on the hill top were nicknamed Phiri ('of the hill') and those who slept at the foot of the hill and had to level or lay out the grass were called Banda ('those who tread the grass under their feet'). So it came to pass that the two clans were created in this way. The advantage was that the creation of these clans made it possible for anyone from the Banda clan to marry into the Phiri clan and vice versa.³²

Anthropological and historical research have interpreted this and other similar narratives as constituting a kind of charter myth that explains the emergence of the early dual structure of Chewa/Maravi society.³³ According to this reading, the Banda, the people of the plains, lived in the area long before the advent of the Phiri, the people of the hills.³⁴ With the coming of the Phiri, mixing between the two groups led to the so-called Maravi states of Kalonga, Undi and Lundu, whose political power was based upon the control of trade routes in ivory, cloth, slaves and other goods. In the beginning, the political structure within these

30 Schoffeleers, *Spirit Worship*.

31 Schoffeleers, *Chisumphi and Mbona Cults*, p. 154.

32 S. J. Ntara, *The History of the Chewa* (Wiesbaden, Steiner, 1976), p. 6.

33 M. Marwick, 'History and Tradition in East Central Africa through the Eyes of the Northern Rhodesian Chewa', *Journal of African History*, 4 (1963), pp. 375–390; K. Phiri, *Chewa History in Central Malawi and the Rise of Oral Tradition 1600–1900* (PhD Dissertation, University of Wisconsin, 1975); Schoffeleers, *River of Blood*.

34 Among anthropologists and historians the advent of the Phiri is thought to have taken place in numerous migratory waves sometime between the fourteenth and the fifteenth centuries.

states was characterised by a dual structure, with the Banda controlling the territorial rain shrines responsible for the fertility of the land and the people, and the Phiri exercising secular power. Over time this relationship gradually faded away and the Phiri took over the rain cult and integrated it into their ancestor shrines, leaving to the Banda only the village-based masked association of *nyau*. A ritual and political landscape evolved in which the Phiri-controlled rain shrines began to be established at the foot of hills, and the village-based *nyau* societies of the Banda became associated with pools.

The decline of the Maravi states began around the middle of the eighteenth century.³⁵ The reason, or the 'context', was mainly the changing colonial system in which the Maravi states were involved. The arrival of the Portuguese in the sixteenth century had played a major economic role in the formation of the Maravi states, and now the establishment of new colonies in Latin America and the Caribbean led to a process of decentralization. New slave markets in Zanzibar and the Caribbean led to an increasing demand for slaves and to a change in traded goods. Former prestige goods such as ivory and gold became less important and were increasingly superseded by slaves. New groups entered the stage, all of them, although with different motives, engaged in the slave trade. Events moved very fast. The four most important parties involved – the Yao coming from Mozambique, the Swahili from the coast, the Ngoni from South Africa and the British in the shape of David Livingstone – arrived on the scene within a time span of only twenty years, between 1840 and 1860. As a result, the political landscape in the area changed drastically. Formerly, Chewa chiefs had acted as rulers of the land but now the Yao and Ngoni were raiding and ransacking the Chewa villages. When Livingstone was touring the Msinja area in 1866 he noted:

We turned in the direction of the paramount chief Chisumphu (sic), whom we found to be only traditionally great ... They [the Chewa] are like a rope of sand, there is no cohesion among them and each village is nearly independent of every other: they mutually distrust each other.³⁶

During the second half of the nineteenth century, a significant proportion of the Chewa population in Central Malawi was either subjugated by Ngoni rule, or fled into Ngoni-free areas, or was sold to the Swahili as slaves. Consequently, the ritual centres also suffered. At the turn of the century a group of Ngoni retainers destroyed the old shrine centre at Msinja. Although the shrine officials managed to rescue the sacred drum, the most important ritual object of the Msinja shrine, and tried to establish a new shrine centre at Tsangoma, it never attained the unifying ritual and political importance of the old Msinja shrine. At the beginning of the twentieth century, the British defeated the Yao and the Ngoni and took control, and the Chewa regained cultural authority in the area. However it seemed that the old political and ritual structures had more or less fallen apart.

In a way, the processes of colonial territorialisation did not differ much from the way the Ngoni had occupied the country and subjugated its people. Indeed, in the eyes of the Chewa, early British colonial rule was in many ways akin to the domination of the Ngoni. The British system of forced labour was felt to be similar to the earlier slave trade and the mission politics of widespread education resembled the Ngoni's attempts to oppress ritual activity, which had only been partially successful due to the invaders' limited numbers. In both cases, territorialisation was not just about the acquisition and appropriation of land but also that of space and operated on both a physical and a symbolic level. The objective was

35 H. W. Langworthy, *A History of Undi's Kingdom to 1890. Aspects of Chewa History* (PhD Dissertation, Boston University, 1969); K. Phiri, 'Precolonial States of Central Africa: Towards a Reconstruction of their History', *Society of Malawi Journal*, 14, 1 (1989), pp. 1–29.

36 H. Waller, *The Last Journals of David Livingstone in Central Africa*, Vol. I (London, J. Murray, 1874), p. 130.

hegemony in the realm of men and in the realm of meaning. What differed were the specific media by which the processes of territorialisation proceeded. The processes of money and mind, 'commerce and Christianity' as Livingstone had put it, proved to be much more effective than the use of sheer military force.

Given the process of political decentralisation it is hardly surprising that the conflicts that emerged arose not in the domain of the rain shrines – as for example among the Shona who had maintained their hierarchical system³⁷ – but in the domain of *nyau*.³⁸ From the beginning of the twentieth century onwards, tensions between *nyau* and missionaries were an increasingly standard issue for the colonial government.³⁹ The arguments raised by the missionaries against *nyau* mainly concerned the 'obscene' songs and the appearance of seemingly naked dancers in the presence of women. For the missionaries *nyau* had therefore to be banned 'in the name of morality'. The representatives of *nyau* responded in an equally negative fashion to the growing missionary influence in their villages. The effects of hut tax, labour migration, the missionary policy of widespread elementary education and the end of the First World War with soldiers returning home with new ideas, hopes and, above all, money, had led to a gradual fragmentation of village life. The representatives of *nyau* complained about a lack of respect of the youth and a general decline of morality. What was at stake was, of course, power or, more precisely, the legitimacy of it.

From the end of the 1930s onwards, conflicts with *nyau* declined. With a mixture of ridicule and nostalgia missionaries and colonial officers alike then began to lament the 'decay' and 'degeneration' of *nyau*, referring in particular to the many new masks depicting scenes and influences from colonial life, from movie figures such as Charlie Chaplin to bicycles and motor cars. Although these ritual innovations actually helped to maintain the notion of cultural belonging and distinctiveness, as has been seen above, in Britain such comments were nevertheless interpreted as fitting into a pattern of increasing 'tribal disintegration'.

A new awareness of 'tradition' had emerged which led to the series of prize schemes and essay competitions launched by the International African Institute which encouraged the young, local elite to reflect upon their history and culture in their own language.⁴⁰ One such example was *Our African Way of Life*,⁴¹ edited and translated by the Scottish missionary, Cullen Young, and by Hastings Kamuzu Banda, Young's former student in Kasungu/Central Malawi who had left the country first for South Africa and then, with the help of a scholarship, for the US where he studied medicine.⁴² Together with Cullen Young, Banda wrote an introduction to this collection in which he stressed especially the moral value of *nyau* covered by one of the essays:

37 See T. Ranger, *Revolt in Southern Rhodesia 1896–1897* (Evanston, Evanston University Press, 1967); T. Ranger, 'Religious Studies and Political Economy. The Mwari Cult and Peasant Experience in Southern Rhodesia', in W. van Binsbergen and J. M. Schoffeleers (eds), *Theoretical Explanations in African Religion* (London, Routledge, 1985), pp. 287–321.

38 It is interesting to note that a local intellectual such as G. S. Mwase, founder of the Central Province Native Association, sympathised more with the rain shrines than with *nyau*, stressing explicitly their territorial (ie national) character, rather than the village-oriented associations of *nyau*. See G. S. Mwase, *Strike a Blow and Die* (Cambridge, MA, Harvard University Press, 1966).

39 See I. Linden, *Catholics, Peasants and Chewa Resistance in Nyasaland, 1899–1939* (London, Heinemann, 1974) and the reference cited therein.

40 An expression of this was the new genre of indigenous literature and ethnography induced and sponsored by missionaries and the International African Institute. See P. Probst, 'Imagination and Repräsentation. Variationen Indigener Ethnographie in Malawi', in H. Behrend and T. Geider (eds), *Afrikaner schreiben zurück*. (Köln, Köppe, 1998), pp. 81–102.

41 C. Young, H. Banda, J. Kambalame, E. Chidzalo and J. Chadangalala (eds), *Our African Way of Life* (London, 1946).

42 After the war Banda went to Edinburgh, where he accidentally ran into Cullen Young who was then working for the Institute.

When we turn to the instruction technique for the male sex we enter an area of very great interest indeed although, to be quite frank, it has not been so recognised by any European observer. This has meant a grievous gulf of misunderstanding between Europeans and Africans, affecting contacts by Government servants and missionaries alike ... For some sixty years we have frowned upon and, indeed, opposed what Government and mission took to be a more or less a licentious 'harvest' or 'fertility' orgy local to the Chewa and Chipeta areas. Actually, as will be seen in these pages, it is a central part of the educational technique, fundamental in the preparation of the male for adult life within the community and maintaining at the heart of the community itself a continuing reverence for the social ideal as Africa sees it. ... The description of the various steps in instruction and initiation for the adolescent youth, as given here, reflects the younger generation's slackening hold upon the old things. Its chronological sequences are not wholly correct, but it is clear on the purpose of *vinyau* (often referred to as *gule*, *masewero*, or *mzinda*) and on the line of teaching always followed. *Vinyau* is a primitive masonic brotherhood, with its special vocabulary and phraseology and with its rigid restriction to initiates only. *Vinyau* is also a curiously parallel institution to 'carnival' as practised along the Mediterranean shore. It has the same masks and antics, the same temporary relaxation of customary law, the same appearance of licence. But no Chewa man has the full status of man if he has not been through its initiation and instructional processes.⁴³

The passage stems from 1946; yet the combination of a cultural universalisation of *nyau* on the one hand with the ethnic localisation of society on the other already signals how *nyau* became interwoven into the fabric of national politics some twenty years later. In the late 1950s the political climate in Malawi, then still Nyasaland, had changed distinctively. After nearly four decades abroad, Banda returned to Malawi to lead the local opposition against colonial rule. Within a few years he managed to take over the political leadership. Among the aims of the new local government was the strengthening of cultural identity among the country's population, especially its youth. For this, Banda reminded his followers of *nyau*'s teachings of respect, obedience and discipline and identified *nyau* as a kind of cultural role model suitable not only for the Malawian youth but for the Malawian population in general. In the years following independence in 1964, *nyau* was thus systematically represented as an icon of national Malawian culture with *nyau* dances performing at political rallies and national holidays.⁴⁴ It was a form of symbolic politics, which explicitly appealed to the significance of local institutions by transferring their meaning into a national context.

However, just as the establishment of Bunda College of Agriculture in the immediate vicinity of the Bunda rain shrine was no more than a calculated manipulation within the sphere of public imagination, so was the political focus on *nyau*. With the renaming of the old Nyasaland African Congress as the Malawi Congress Party, new subgroups were established, among them the Malawi Young Pioneers and the Malawi Youth League. The reorganisation of the party allowed the state to keep a firm grip on the population. Every village had to elect local party representatives to liaise with the central party. A branch and cell structure evolved whose organisational hierarchy was based upon the local political hierarchy running from an ordinary village headman, to Group village headman to the TA chief, the traditional authority. Furthermore, membership of the *Malawi Youth League* often became identical with membership in *nyau*. In effect, a political system had been created in which *nyau* acted as a sort of transmission belt for the interest of the party. In this way, any organised opposition to the government was attacked quickly and forcefully at the local village level. Although the interests involved were not the same – with *nyau* aiming to maintain its relative autonomy on the one hand and the party/state aiming to strengthen its

43 Young *et al*, *Our African Way*, pp. 24–25.

44 See P. Short, *Banda* (London, Routledge, 1974); L. Vail and L. White, 'Tribalism in the Political History of Malawi', in L. Vail (ed), *The Creation of Tribalism in Southern Africa* (Oxford, James Currey, 1989), pp. 151–192; A. C. Ross, 'The Political Role of the Witch-finder in Southern Malawi during the Cabinet Crisis of 1964 to 1965', in R. G. Willis (ed), *Witchcraft and Healing* (Edinburgh, Edinburgh University Press, 1969), pp. 55–70.

hegemony on the other – it was a system that worked, at least in the early years after independence, when much money, material and energy were generated to achieve Banda's vision of transforming Malawi into the 'Denmark of Central Africa'.⁴⁵

From Instrumentalisation to Modernisation: Changing Contexts II

Let us now return to Chief Chilowa and the Bunda rain shrine. As discussed, the encroachment of *nyau* into the domain of the rain shrine started in the early 1970s, which witnessed the growing importance of the nation-state and the incorporation of Malawi into an international market economy. While the Bunda shrine had already become part of the colonial hegemony at the beginning of the twentieth century, the influence of outside forces were more forcefully felt after independence. As they became more closely integrated into the national Malawian economy, people became exposed to a new and constant flow of money, ideas, techniques and images – factors that had exerted their influence before but which received a new momentum from the mid-1960s onwards. The results articulated themselves in part in people's neglect of the sexual restrictions and moral obligations associated with the *mfunde* rain calling ritual in February.⁴⁶ However, from a structural point of view, of more importance is the recent encroachment of *nyau* into the premises of the rain shrine.

As discussed, the incumbency of a ritual office within the rain cult prohibits the simultaneous engagement in *nyau* activities and vice versa. On a spatial level, the presence of the rain shrine thereby acted as a kind of structural counterweight against the numerical majority of *nyau*. On a social and political level, it ensured and maintained the distinction and specific profile of the ruling Phiri elite *vis-à-vis* the rest of the society. On a symbolic level, it demonstrated the authority of the Chief and his ritual officials to be in command of the media constructing locality as context, i.e. a world with shared assumptions and values that structure social interaction and social expectations.

That these avoidance rules are no longer respected illustrates a profound transformation of postcolonial power relations. Superficially, the most visible sign of this transformation was the establishment of the Bunda College of Agriculture right next to the Bunda rain shrine in 1971. Although, as already argued, this was merely a calculated symbolic gesture it served the purpose of imbuing Banda with chiefly attributes that underlined his status as 'the hero' (*ngwazi*) and the country's 'first guardian' (*nkhoswe No. 1*), ie a leader who stands both inside and outside of 'tradition'. The transformation had, however, started a number of years before these public signs and events. Shortly after independence the new government passed a number of bills aimed at stimulating the country's agricultural development by fostering cash crop production and changing the customary land tenure. The official government view was that:

Under our present system of landholding and land cultivation, no one, either as an institution or as an individual, will lend us money for developing our land because our present methods of landholding and land cultivation are uneconomic and wasteful. They put responsibility on

45 Short, *Banda*, p. 155. This is not to say that there had been no critique of Banda's regime. In fact, the so-called 'cabinet crisis' of 1964 was an expression of distinct protest against Banda's regime. For other 'popular responses', also on the level of *nyau*, see W. C. Chirwa, *Dancing towards Repression: Popular Culture and Political Repression in Malawi. 1960s — Early 1990s* (unpublished paper, History Workshop, University of Witwatersrand, 1994); White and Vail, *Power and the Praise Poem*.

46 Chief Chilowa's statement that the last *mfunde* ritual was conducted in the 1950s is highly significant for it refers to a time when the colonial government introduced new agricultural techniques, which met the fierce resistance of the villagers. Seen in this light, the rejection of the ritual behaviour necessary for a successful *mfunde* can be understood as a statement about the loss of effectiveness in controlling the construction of locality.

no one. No one is responsible here ... because no one holds land as an individual. Land is held in common. They say everybody's baby is nobody's baby at all.⁴⁷

According to this argument, individual land ownership would result in security of tenure, greater responsibility and the opportunity to raise loans using family land as security. In turn, this would encourage individual families to invest in the land. In support of this thesis, the UN Capital Fund gave money to launch a nationwide Land Development Programme. Lilongwe district was among the four districts selected as pilot projects and received UN funding of US\$28 million from 1968 to 1978.⁴⁸

One of the first measures taken was the demarcation and registration of land. This entailed the confirmation of a series of existing plot boundaries among various households and between villages. In addition, a new institution was established, the Agricultural Development and Marketing Corporation (ADMARC). As part of a state-controlled market, ADMARC bought the harvest of the peasants and sold the cash crops at auctions in Limbe and Lilongwe to foreign buyers on the world market. Some of the money thus earned provided the basis for loans and credit for the farmers. In this way, the latter were able to obtain fertilisers, seeds, pesticide packages or larger investments such as animals, ox-drawn implements and maize mills. To try and ensure that credit was used effectively, extension workers were sent out to train the farmers. The projects also involved infrastructural development, with investment in roads, community halls, schools and under-five clinics.

During the early and mid-1970s, the project seemed to be living up to expectations and agricultural productivity increased. However, the project had induced changes and processes that were quite different from those originally envisaged. Land registration and the introduction of individual land ownership had been widely rejected⁴⁹ and the project had strengthened pre-existing economic inequalities. In general, peasants who were already well-off with access to good farming land became richer, and poor villagers remained poor. In other words, a latent peasant differentiation had set in, creating a new peasant elite parallel to the local authority structure.

The massive attempts to 'modernise' the population also had its effects on *nyau*. Indeed, as Mkandawire, a Malawian sociologist studying the Lilongwe Rural Development Project (LRDP) noted, 'the penetration of the LRDP has increasingly come to link the *nyau* society into a wider policy making system, in the sense that the society has increasingly become an integral part of the project'.⁵⁰ *Nyau* leaders were sought after for the project's administration and vice versa. Thus, recognizing that *nyau* commanded a high status among the local population, officials sought to legitimise the project by using *nyau* as a medium to support and assist its activities. *Nyau* was sent out to mobilise the villagers to attend agricultural shows, extension meetings and various other development-related activities. For *nyau* members, the motives for involvement were money and status and the project soon came to be seen as a source of resources and benefits. Knowing the relevant people

47 Malawi Government, Hansard, April 4, 1967, cited in R. M. Mkandawire, *Agrarian Change and Rural Development Strategy in Malawi. A Case Study of the Chewa Peasantry in the Lilongwe Rural Development Project* (PhD Dissertation, University of East Anglia, 1984), p. 227.

48 The existence of the rain shrine in this district did not play a major role in the decision. Rather, it was because one of Banda's closest allies, R. J. Chizanja (formerly chairman of the MCP of the Central Region, then regional minister and, from 1973, Minister of Trade and Commerce) was from Lilongwe South. To a large degree the instrumentalisation of *nyau* for party/state politics had been his work.

49 Land demarcation and registration caused conflicts within families over the question of who belongs to the family. Based on the bilateral tendency in Chewa social organisation this issue was, and still is, a matter of negotiation. Land registration threatened the fluid character of land issues and was not accepted. In addition, the varying quality of land had not been considered in the titling process. Last but not least, the traditional authorities also rejected titling because the land allocation officers hired for the project were now deemed superior to the village headmen and curtailed their power to settle land disputes.

50 Mkandawire, *Agrarian Change*, p. 303.

increases your chances of obtaining loans and credits, even if you were unable to pay back loans taken out earlier. In addition, *nyau* performances have to be paid for, and thus they became an important way of earning money. Formerly, *nyau* performances had mainly taken place on the occasion of a burial or on female initiation, for which the family members of the deceased or the village headmen had to pay, but now rich peasants invited the society to dance in order to enhance their status. *Nyau* performances are always watched by a crowd of people who closely monitor the skill and quality of the drummers and dancers, and the number of people who enter the dance ground to give their token of respect is seen as an indicator of the relative appreciation or critique not only of the performance itself but also of the place – the village – where the performance takes place. Increasingly, *nyau* became involved in economic politics with rich farmers inviting *nyau* and distributing substantial sums to the figures in an effort to enhance their status and prestige. This, in turn, led to increased competition between the various *nyau* societies in the district. Spatial networks of *nyau* evolved, comprising a number of village headmen who assisted each other in their *nyau* activities, often under the patronage of wealthy farmers or local party politicians. New masks, new songs and new dances were created. Most importantly, however, the number of *nyau* societies increased. While formerly *nyau* had been restricted to chiefs and senior village group headmen, now even minor village headman became *mwini mzinda*. Indeed, it was during these busy years that Chief Chilowa, keeper of the Bunda rain shrine, decided to abandon the avoidance rule towards *nyau*. The situation was clear: the rain cult was communal in dimension and it was not possible to make a profit on services rendered to the population as a whole. To let *nyau* enter the structural space of the rain cult seemed one way out of the restrictions their positions entailed.

Aspects of Difference

The focus above on economic issues notwithstanding, it would be misleading to see the changes outlined in the realm of *nyau* only as an expression of rational choice and individual profit maximisation, even though such motives certainly existed. Rather, the spatial expansion of *nyau* and its changing relationship with the *chisumphi* rain cult bring to light the different ways in which the two institutions have tried to maintain control over the means and processes of constructing locality in a rapidly changing environment. Obviously, *nyau* was better 'equipped' than *chisumphi*, but how and why?

The answer to this question is complex and requires distinctions to be drawn between *nyau* as performance, *nyau* as a ritual institution and *nyau* as a mask. The performance dimension, how *nyau* performances produce locality, has been discussed already. The institutional dimension illuminates another aspect of difference. Central here is the relationship of plurality and individuality on the one hand and singularity and mediality on the other. That is, while within the *chisumphi* rain cult the dominant figure is the single spirit concept of *chauta* or *chisumphi*, to whom a limited and fixed number of ritual officials with personally prescribed tasks take up contact through prayers and sacrifices offered to the ancestors of the shrine, within *nyau* there is a multitude of animal and ancestor spirits, each represented by a single masked dancer whose role is not defined by office and person. Thus, any member of *nyau* can dance a spirit, provided he has the talent and the money to buy the material for the mask that represents that spirit. The increasing process of individualisation established by the Lilongwe Rural Development Project in the economic sector could be argued to correspond with the moment of individualisation within *nyau*. The third dimension, the mask, is directly related to the former. It is based upon the *passiones*-like character of *nyau* performance in the sense that the dancer is caught by the power of something – an event, a thing, a person, an animal – which the dancer enacts and visualises

through the mask.⁵¹ To understand what is meant by this, it is necessary to focus on the relationship between mask and image, which means focusing on the relationship between *chithunzi* and *fano*.

In Chewa thought, every person is endowed with his or her own image or form (*chinthunzi*). *Chinthunzi* stems from the noun *nthunzi* meaning shade. As such, *chinthunzi* acts, so to speak, as a person's double or other. Every person is born with his own shade.⁵² When the person dies his or her image or form (*chinthunzi*) leaves the body (*thupi*) and transforms itself first into a ghost (*chiwanda*). In this potentially dangerous condition – people say that a *chiwanda* is *hot* – it roams around in the village until it reaches its normative condition as a – now *cool* – ancestor spirit (*mzimu*) either through the performance of the *mphalo*, commemorative rite, or through other acts of remembrance showing respect and reverence to the deceased. What follows from the above is the insight that the ancestor spirits of the Chewa have no form, no image, no *chinthunzi*. Only the living have these properties.⁵³ Yet, if the ancestor spirits have no image, no form, no *chinthunzi*, what then are the *nyau* who – after all – are said to be understood as embodiments of these spirits? The answer lies in the concept of *fano*. *Fano* means image as well, but not in the sense of being a direct representation of reality but in the sense of being a product of imagination. The verb from which it stems is *ku fana* meaning to be like, to resemble. Thus, *fano* is rather an inner image, it is perceived more with the heart than with the eyes, its relationship with the object it represents is one of affective likeness and resemblance not one of visual identity.⁵⁴

The implications of *fano* and *chithunzi* seem to govern the conventions of portraiture within *nyau*. Two sorts of portrayals, two layers of image can be distinguished. The first category consists of depersonalised forms or images, or rather images of experience and remembrance in the sense of *fano* constituting particular genres or roles. Their importance rests in the role they have within *nyau* performances as a moral and educational play. They represent certain aspects of mythical, historical and/or social experience that are relevant for village life and village morality: *kalulu*, the hare, *simoni*, the European, or *chadzunda*, the

51 On this issue of *passiones* see G. Lienhardt, *Divinity and Experience* (Oxford, Oxford University Press, 1961); F. Kramer, *The Red Fes. Art and Possession in Africa*. (London, Verso, 1993); P. Probst, 'Picture Dance. Reflections on Nyau Image and Experience', *Iwalewa Forum*, 3, 1 (2000), pp. 17–32.

52 A person consists of a body (*thupi*), a life force (*moyo*) and a double or other (*chinthunzi*). All three develop over time. A new born baby becomes a social person through the care of its parents. In the course of time the person matures and develops character (*khalidwe*), heart and feelings, sentiments (*mtima*). Both *khalidwe* *mtima* appear as expressions of *moyo*, the life force. This life force begins at the time of fertilisation in the mother's womb. After birth it manifests itself in the *chinthunzi*. Only death (*imfa*) brings an end to this process.

53 Some evidence for the validity of this argument is the fact that many people are still rather reluctant to be photographed. They fear that the photograph might steal (*kwathula*) the *chinthunzi* of a person. It is a widespread and popular notion that a person who is photographed might lose his or her form or image, which wanders over and gets frozen and fixed in the photograph making it impossible for the image to return to its original owner.

54 Endowed with this quality, *fano* is associated with the idea of spreading and extended action. It is a notion perhaps best illustrated by the individual experience of dreaming. At times the creation of new *nyau* masks is the result of dreams. Some, but not all, dreams are thought to be caused by doubles and ancestor spirits who travel and visit the living, making them see things. See also G. Sembereka, 'The Place of Gule Wamkulu in Dreams attributed to Spirits. Nominal Reincarnation and Spirit Possession: The Nankumba Experience', *Society of Malawi Journal*, 49, 1 (1996), pp. 1–31. Dream images are thus not actively produced but rather passively received. The notion of spreading is further evident in the sensual force attributed to *nyau* figures. When *nyau* mask makers are urged to reflect upon the masks they produce, they say the mask is an image, a *fano*. In doing so they emphasise the special presence of the force or power that rests in the figure/image as some kind of *moyo*, life force. A particular feature of this force or power is its permeability, a capacity likened to the air and the wind whose presence is perceived by the rustling leaves of the graveyard, the homestead of *nyau* and the spirits of the deceased; see Birch de Aguiar, *Inscribing the Mask*, p. 187.

chief. Yet beyond this depersonalised feature of *nyau* there is often a concrete personal element involved. In other words, *nyau* are not only generic and emblematic portraits, they are often also representational portraits.⁵⁵ That is to say, a mask maker can shape the mask of a particular genre in the mode of likeness to a recently deceased person.⁵⁶ In the course of time and with the fading away of memory, representational masks become generic masks again. Thus, *nyau* masks always entail a double representation. They depict experiences just as they recall that these experiences are always bound to concrete, but mortal, individuals.

The *nyau* pantheon is said to contain well over 200 different *nyau* characters.⁵⁷ Although we lack adequate knowledge of the range and scope of *nyau* figures in the past, it is evident that the number of *nyau* images has increased over time. It is important to recall that the meaning of the *nyau* masks is always polyvalent. That is, the meaning of the mask varies not only with the specific ritual context in which it appears but old masks can also be imbued with new meanings, or new masks can be presented as refractions of old ones. To some extent, the meaning of these masks appears in the songs the women dedicate to it. Some of these songs are hermetic chants known only to insiders. They refer to past events and/or the symbolic significance of certain ritual acts or objects. Others are more down to earth. In these songs the women openly express their concerns, their feelings and longings. Thus, a song addressed to *chadzunda*, the chief, for example, might depict a chief who is fond of drinking, thereby neglecting the village. Other songs refer to the bad behaviour of prostitutes, the stinginess of a certain businessman or the impotence of one's own husband. Others again refer to the plague of AIDS, the feeling of hunger, rumours of witchcraft or the distrust in national politics. In this way, *nyau* performances constitute a kind of a village-based public sphere, the songs expressing something like public opinion. It is this public character of *nyau* which, in particular, indicates its highly context-oriented nature. By creating new figures and attributing new meanings to old masks, *nyau* actively adjusts and adapts elements outside the village sphere and transforms them into the something belonging to *nyau*. A process of ritual domestication is at work that tames the outside forces threatening the capability of locality construction by making them part of *nyau*. In contrast to the *chisumphi* rain cult, which has not only been unable to cope with the increasing monetisation of social relations produced by larger scale contexts such as the nation-state and the world market, but has also failed to account for the new forces on the level of meaning, *nyau* has – so far – successfully gained control over these forces, thereby remaining in command of the context generative dimension of locality construction.

Reshaping the Urban and the Rural

A clear indication of this (relative) success is the recent spatial spread and dissemination of *nyau*. In combination with larger contexts, such as the Malawi Congress Party, *nyau* officials have created new spatial networks in which the arrangement of expensive *nyau* performances such as initiation ceremonies or commemorative mortuary rituals are co-ordinated and organised in order to make the performance more attractive and less expensive for the one who invites *nyau*. Due to the popularity of *nyau* performances, on the

55 J. M. Borgatti, and R. Brilliant (eds), *Likeness and Beyond. Portraits from Africa and Beyond* (New York, The Center for African Art, 1990).

56 As Birch de Aguilar, *Inscribing the Mask*, p. 134ff, reports, a newly made *chadzunda* face mask, for example, can resemble the face of a recently deceased chief and the likeness between the two can actually be recognised by the audience. While some see only *the chief* as a genre, others perceive and recognise the likeness between the figure and the deceased.

57 Personal communication, Father Claude Boucher.

one hand, and the steady decline of the Malawian economy, on the other, for some dancing *nyau* has become an alternative and important source of income.⁵⁸ This has been especially true for the youth, who have often had to leave the urban centres for lack of money and employment. Indeed, the ongoing decline of the Malawian economy has led to a subtle reshaping and reordering of the relationship between the rural and the urban.

Under the acute experience of impoverishment and the awareness of the pure rhetoric of popular slogans such as 'progress' and 'democracy' the rural has – in many ways more unwillingly than willingly – received a new, although ambivalent, esteem. While notions of home and belonging prevail, the urban as a place of money, wealth and private desires has not lost its fascination. *Nyau* is dealing with this ambivalence. The songs of *nyau* are full of them. There is no space here to analyse these songs; suffice it to say that the content of *nyau* songs shows the manifold tensions and contradictions inherent in contemporary village life. No doubt, these tensions have affected *nyau* too. In fact, old members of *nyau* complain about the changes that have taken place over the years. They lament the lack of strength and discipline of the *nyau* youth and explain this in relation to their perceptions of a general weakening of society. While 'in the olden days' initiation into *nyau* used to last three to four weeks, nowadays it takes hardly more than four days. Many of the young dancers, they say, are only after money. They try to dodge out of communal work. For example, the construction of the large animal figures such as the *njovu*, the elephant, or the *kasiya maliro*, the antelope, requires the gathering of maize husks at night when the rest of the village is at sleep. The young folks, however, are lazy. They prefer to sleep or to chase girls in the neighbourhood. The construction of these figures had therefore become more difficult.

The nostalgic tone mirrors the change of *nyau*, a change, however, which is not recent. Due to *nyau*'s capability to focus not only on the context generative but also on the context driven dimension of locality, changes within *nyau* are, so to speak, endemic to the society. Yet, the recent dissemination of *nyau*, its spatial spread, reveals a distinctly new element in the longstanding relationship between *nyau* and the political centre. By ritually integrating the outside forces of the larger scale contexts that affect and impinge upon the construction of locality on behalf of *nyau* the conversion of these forces has led to a two-fold development. On the one hand it has led to a certain qualitative flattening of *nyau*. This concerns the reduction of the length of the rituals, the number of secret codes the novices have to learn and particular symbolic acts that express the close relationship between *nyau*, the *chisumphu* rain cult and their common reference to the creation myth. On the other hand, it has led to the spatial expansion of *nyau*. Instead of becoming enshrined and encapsulated by the larger scale context of the Malawian nation-state in which *nyau* is embedded, it has managed to enlarge its own context. On the level of power and politics, this process might also be understood as kind of *inversion* of territorialisation. That is, after decades of colonial and postcolonial territorialisation, understood here as similar to the production of locality as a hegemonic process of appropriation and extension of cultural space directed from the urban/centre into the rural/periphery, an inversion of this process has set in as a way of re-appropriating national space back into ritual and local place.

A note of caution seems to be appropriate however. In view of the two characters whose biographies have been detailed above, chief Chilowa and chief Kalumba, one needs to bear in mind that rituals are not abstract and autonomous entities, but consist of concrete

58 During the course of my research I came across a number of men who were what might be called part-time *nyau* professionals. During the dry season they left for Mozambique to learn new *nyau* songs and dances. Upon their return their newly acquired skills led to invitations to *nyau* performances at home. When asked for their motives, financial reasons were ranked alongside issues of status and prestige.

individuals who make them 'work'. Thus, the process described here is not irreversible. It might well be that, in future, the Bunda rain shrine will be revived, provided that people feel the need to do so and imbue it with new meaning and new importance.

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